Lesson 2.4: Strategy by task type: analysis, research, drafting, brainstorming

Claude Certified Associate – Foundations (CCAO-F) · Module 2: Prompting & Task Execution · Lesson 4 · 21:02

Description

Many people find one prompt style that works and use it for everything: short, confident, one final answer. That style gives you one safe idea when you wanted a brainstorm, and an answer from memory, with nothing you can check, when you wanted research. This lesson teaches you to name the task type first, because the type decides what good looks like. Analysis is good when it's supported, research when it's sourced and current, drafting when it fits the reader, and brainstorming when it has range before anyone chooses. You see where the guidance comes from: the official exam guide, Anthropic's official prep course, the Claude Platform Docs, the Claude blog and Claude Academy. Then four real jobs for this course run in Claude Desktop. Claude analyses our own Module 2 notes, drafts a one-page study sheet from that analysis, checks three dated claims on Anthropic's pages with web search, and brainstorms practice tasks, then shortlists them. Each job gets its own prompt, its own feature and its own test. The lesson ends with one exam-style scenario, reasoned out loud, and the cue to the Module 2 quiz.

Learning outcomes

By the end of this lesson you can:

1. Tell the four task types apart by what good looks like for each.
2. Adapt the prompt, and pick the feature, for analysis, research, drafting and brainstorming.
3. Judge each kind of output by its own test.

Chapters

Time	Chapter
00:00	Preview and outcomes
00:37	Why it matters
01:24	The idea: four jobs, four kinds of good
03:15	Straight from the source
04:54	Hands-on: four real jobs
19:02	Exam angle
20:16	Recap and Module 2 quiz

The idea

One question first: what does good look like here? There are four common kinds of job, the four task types, and each has its own answer (this course's card, built from the sources below):

	Analysis	Research	Drafting	Brainstorming
Where the material is	In what you give it	Out there (the web, connected apps)	Your notes, plus the reader	Nowhere yet
Good means	Supported	Sourced and current	Fits the reader and purpose	Range, then a choice
What to ask for	A clear question; the quotes behind each finding; permission to say the material can't tell	Which sources count; a link and the exact words per fact; search, not memory; what couldn't be confirmed	Audience, purpose, tone, length and shape; an example if you have a style to match; only the facts you gave	A number; range; a few unexpected ones; no ranking yet; no example; then a shortlist step against your own criteria
Which feature fits	Attach the file	Web search for a few quick facts; Research for many sources and a full report	An artifact, for something you'll edit, reuse or share	Plain chat, then a follow-up
How to judge it	Check a quote against the source	Open the source: does it say that, on whose page, and is it current?	Read it as the reader would; trace a fact back	How different are the ideas really? Then your criteria, your choice

The dial. Put the four on one line: evidence on the left (analysis, research), range on the right (drafting, brainstorming).

Same six parts, different weight. You already have the six parts of a prompt (Lesson 2.1), chains (Lesson 2.2) and "write down what good looks like first" (Lesson 2.3). The task type decides which parts carry the weight. Constraints and evidence carry analysis and research.

Audience, format and examples carry drafting. Range carries brainstorming, and there you leave the example out, because one example pulls every idea toward itself.

Generate first, judge later. For brainstorming, ask for the list without judging it, then shortlist in a second step. That's a two-step chain, as in Lesson 2.2. This is the course's rule, built from the sources below; Anthropic doesn't publish it as a named technique.

Three questions for any job: what do I ask for, which feature fits, and how will I judge it?

Straight from the source (what the lesson shows)

- **Exam guide, page 4:** "Exam items are written against these objectives." Domain 1, Prompting and Task Execution (14% of scored items), fourth bullet: "Adapt prompting strategies based on task type (analysis, research, drafting, brainstorming)". This course labels it task 1.4. The guide lists its task statements as unnumbered bullets, so 1.4 is our label, not the guide's. Features in general were Lesson 1.2. Using Claude for research and planning belongs to Domain 4 (Module 4).
- **Anthropic's official prep course, Prompting & Task Execution:** the last of its learning objectives, "Adapt prompting strategy to the task type: analysis, research, drafting, or brainstorming". That's why this lesson closes Module 2.
- **Claude Platform Docs, Prompting best practices, Long context prompting:** "Ground responses in quotes": for long document tasks, ask Claude to quote the relevant parts of the documents first, before it carries out its task.
- **Claude blog, Best practices for prompt engineering:** give permission to express uncertainty. Its example: "If the data is insufficient to draw conclusions, say so rather than speculating."
- **Claude Platform Docs, Prompting best practices, Research and information gathering:** define what a successful answer looks like, and ask Claude to verify information across multiple sources.
- **Claude Platform Docs, Prompting Claude Sonnet 5.5, Tool use in chat and knowledge work:** Sonnet 5.5 sometimes answers from its training knowledge when a web search would catch details that have changed. The Docs write this for apps that give Claude a search tool; in the app, you can say it in your prompt: "Search; don't answer from memory."
- **Claude Academy, Claude 101, Research for deep dives:** consider web search instead of Research when you need a quick, specific fact, the answer needs only one or two sources, and speed matters more than being comprehensive.
- **Claude blog, Best practices for prompt engineering, "Be explicit and clear" and "Provide context and motivation":** "Tell the model exactly what you want to see. If you want comprehensive output, ask for it." Give context too: the purpose or audience for the output, and how it will be used.

Key terms

- **Task type:** the kind of job (analysis, research, drafting or brainstorming). It changes what good looks like, and so what you ask for.
- **Analysis:** making sense of material you provide: finding patterns, comparing, and drawing conclusions the material supports.
- **Grounding:** asking Claude to quote the material its answer rests on, so you can check it. The Docs call it "ground responses in quotes".
- **Research (the task and the feature):** the task is gathering information from outside sources. Research, the feature, is one way to do it, for many sources and a full report. Web search is the quick way.
- **Drafting:** writing a piece for a specific reader and purpose. It gives you the first version, which you then check and edit.
- **Brainstorming:** generating many varied options before judging any, then choosing against your own criteria. "Generate first, judge later" is the course's rule.

What happened in the hands-on

Claude Desktop on Linux, Chat view, Sonnet 5.5 at Medium, recorded on 2026-10-06 on a real account. The material is real: the published notes of Lessons 2.1 to 2.3, joined into one file of about 7,600 words. So are the jobs: a study sheet for the Module 2 quiz, a re-check of three dated claims in the course notes, and practice tasks for learners. The exact prompts and Claude's replies are in the student kit. One wait is cut, the 40 seconds while the study sheet filled in, and the cut is labelled on screen and said aloud. Every other wait plays in real time.

Job 1: analysis (a normal chat). This chat would make a document worth keeping, so it's a normal chat, not incognito (the Help Center says incognito chats can't create files). In the + menu, Memory was switched off for this one chat, and Web search was unticked, because for analysis the material is the file. The notes file was attached. The prompt had five short lines:

> Task: In the attached notes, sort every wrong option in each lesson's practice scenario by why it fails. Why: to warn learners before the Module 2 quiz. Evidence: quote the option and the line that explains why it's wrong. Question: which reasons come up in more than one lesson? If the notes don't say why, say so rather than guess.

1. **The reply:** all nine wrong options from the three practice scenarios, each quoted with the notes' own reason, sorted into five groups: swapping in a more capable model, extra wording that adds no information, fixing the output instead of the prompt, trusting Claude to grade itself, and splitting the task too far.
2. **The question answered:** "a bigger model" is a trap in all three lessons. "Adds no information" shows up in two lessons, not three. We expected three, but the notes give Lesson 2.2's option B a different reason (thinking is already on with Sonnet 5.5), so Claude kept it apart and quoted why. Its split is backed by quotes.
3. **The permission line worked:** where the notes don't explain a reason separately, the reply says so and adds no reason of its own.
4. **Judged by its test (supported):** one quote, "the same missing facts", searched in the notes file with Ctrl+F: 1 of 1, word for word, in Lesson 2.1's scenario. Off camera, all 19 quoted explanations were checked the same way, and all match.

Job 2: drafting (the same chat, a document). The findings were already in the chat, so the drafting lines carry the weight:

> Task: Turn these findings into a one-page study sheet, as an artifact. Audience: beginners about to take the Module 2 quiz. Tone: calm and plain. Shape: a title, each trap with how to spot it and what to do instead, then a short checklist. Use only facts from the notes.

5. **The draft:** Claude built it as a Claude Docs document in the panel beside the chat: "Module 2 Quiz: Five Traps to Avoid", with five traps (spot it, why it fails, do instead) and a seven-question checklist, "Before you choose an answer".
6. **Judged as the reader:** plain words, calm, and the shape asked for. One fact was traced back: Trap 4 (asking Claude to grade itself) matches group 4 of the analysis, which quotes the notes. But one real problem showed up. One page was asked for, and the draft is 723 words, with three paragraphs per trap. Claude's own comment in the doc offered to shorten the checklist or cut a trap, but those parts were good. Only the length was wrong.
7. **One follow-up, not a new prompt.** This is a one-off fix to a mostly good draft, so it's a follow-up that says what to keep (Lesson 2.3):

> Keep the title, the five traps, the checklist and the tone as they are. Change only the length so it fits on one page: for each trap, just how to spot it and what to do instead, one line each.

8. **The final result:** the same document, edited in place, at 380 words: one page. Each trap has one line to spot it and one to do instead. The title, the intro, the five trap headings and all seven checklist lines are unchanged word for word.

Job 3: research (incognito, web search). Nothing here needed keeping, so this ran in an incognito chat. Web search was unticked (the choice from the analysis chat carried over), so it was ticked on camera. Research, just above it, was left off. Three quick facts, with a search or two each, is a job for web search. A broad question across many sources, ending in a report, is a job for Research (Lesson 1.2).

> Task: Check if three claims from my course notes are still true today. Claim A: From October 6, 2026, new Cowork tasks on Pro and Max plans run in the cloud. Claim B: Claude Haiku 4.5 retires no sooner than October 15, 2026. Claim C: Research needs a paid plan. Sources: Anthropic's own current pages only. Search; don't answer from memory. Return: a table with claim, status (still true, changed or can't confirm), link and exact words. If pages disagree, say so.

9. **The status lines:** searching the web, then a page fetch from Anthropic's old support site, then "Gathering short quotes from official sources". It took about half a minute.
10. **The table:** all three claims "still true", each with a link and the exact words. For claim B, "no sooner than" is a floor, not a date. Claude also said honestly that it couldn't read the Haiku row on the model deprecations page, so its only source for B is the models overview. (This course read that row on 2026-10-06: "Not sooner than October 15, 2026".) Where pages disagree: older copies of the Research article, on the old support domain, still call it a beta in three countries. And it says it used only Anthropic domains.
11. **Judged by its test (sourced):** every link is on support.claude.com or platform.claude.com. Claim A's link was opened in a new browser tab ("Updated this week"). Ctrl+F found Claude's exact words, "on Pro and Max plans run in the cloud": 1 of 1, under "What's changing for Pro and Max plans on October 6".
12. **One judgment stays yours.** Higher up, the same page opens with a heads-up: on October 6, new tasks run in the cloud, and an option "will be removed". That's a notice of a plan. So claim A is still true as a plan, but this page can't prove yet that it has happened.

Job 4: brainstorming (incognito, two steps). A new incognito chat, with no file.

> Task: Brainstorm 15 practice tasks that beginners could try with Claude at work this week. Who: people in operations, marketing, education and communications. Range: cover analysis, research, drafting and brainstorming, and include a few unexpected ones. Don't rank or judge them yet. One line each, tagged with its type.

13. **The list (about ten seconds):** 15 one-line tasks: 3 analysis, 3 research, 4 drafting, 2 brainstorming, and 3 tagged "Unexpected" (play a skeptical stakeholder, rehearse a difficult conversation, build a style guide from your own writing). Judged by range, they really are different. **One slip:** the prompt asked for each to be tagged with its type, and "unexpected" isn't a type. Reading against your own prompt catches that.
14. **Step two, choose:**

> Now shortlist 4, one per task type: under 15 minutes, uses the learner's own non-sensitive files, easy to check. Say why each made it.

15. **The shortlist:** one pick per type, each with a reason against the criteria: feedback themes, a comparison of three tools, a follow-up email from meeting notes, and 20 ideas clustered by effort. Two are adapted to fit the criteria. The comparison now uses documents the learner already has, and the brainstorm pastes in last quarter's topics. These are suggestions. The criteria were the course author's, and the final choice is yours.

Side by side: same model, same app, four strategies. The analysis was judged by its quotes, the draft by its reader, the research by its sources, and the brainstorm by its range, then by our choice.

The exam link

Domain 1, Prompting and Task Execution (14% of scored items). This lesson serves the bullet this course labels **1.4**: "Adapt prompting strategies based on task type (analysis, research, drafting, brainstorming)". The guide lists its task statements as unnumbered bullets; the number 1.4 is this course's label, not the guide's. With it, Module 2 has covered all four Domain 1 bullets this course labels 1.1 to 1.4: effective prompts (Lesson 2.1), decomposition (Lesson 2.2), iteration (Lesson 2.3) and strategy by task type (this lesson).

The lesson's practice scenario (original, written for this course, not from the exam). A communications lead uses one saved prompt for everything: "One polished, final answer in under 100 words. Be precise and confident." She uses it to brainstorm names for a new internal newsletter, and gets one safe, forgettable name. What's the most appropriate next step? A: run the same prompt again on the most capable model. B: turn on Research to see what other teams call their newsletters. C: ask for 20 varied names, unranked, and shortlist them herself. D:

keep the saved prompt, and add "Be creative" at the top. The answer is **C**. Ask first: what kind of job is this? It's brainstorming, so good means range, then a choice, and her prompt asks for one, final and short. A blames the model, the trap in all three Module 2 scenarios. B gathers outside facts, but she needs ideas. D adds pressure, not information, and still asks for one polished, final answer. C changes exactly what this task type needs.

Module 2 quiz

That's Module 2 complete: prompts, chains, iteration, and strategy by task type, from Lesson 2.1 to Lesson 2.4. Next up: the Module 2 quiz, which covers all four lessons (Domain 1, the task statements this course labels 1.1 to 1.4). There's no separate quick check for this lesson; the module quiz takes its place. The exam-style question in this lesson, the quick checks, the module quizzes and the practice exams are all original, written for this course against the official blueprint. They are never copies of the real exam. The study sheet drafted on camera is real course material, but the published quiz items are written fresh after the videos.

Sources (all checked 2026-10-06)

- **Anthropic, *Claude Certified Associate – Foundations Exam Guide*.** Version 1.0, effective July 2026. §3 Intended Audience (p. 2), §6 Domain 1 and detailed objectives (p. 4), Domains 2 to 4 (pp. 4–5), §7 How to Prepare (p. 6). Official download: https://everpath-course-content.s3-accelerate.amazonaws.com/instructor/6nizmqk8tpzpfjvt6qmmav7rh/public/1783542847/Claude+Certified+Associate+%E2%80%93+Foun
- **Anthropic's official CCAO-F prep course,** Course 2, *Prompting & Task Execution* (public course page: learning objectives).
- **Claude Platform Docs,** *Prompting best practices* (Long context prompting: "Ground responses in quotes"; Research and information gathering; Use examples effectively; Control the format of responses; Chain complex prompts): https://platform.claude.com/docs/en/build-with-claude/prompt-engineering/claude-prompting-best-practices
- **Claude Platform Docs,** *Prompting Claude Sonnet 5.5* (Tool use in chat and knowledge work): https://platform.claude.com/docs/en/build-with-claude/prompt-engineering/prompting-claude-sonnet-5-5
- **Claude blog,** *Best practices for prompt engineering* (November 10, 2025: give permission to express uncertainty; be explicit and clear; provide context and motivation; use examples): https://claude.com/blog/best-practices-for-prompt-engineering
- **Claude Academy, Claude 101,** *Research for deep dives* (when to use Research; consider web search instead; tips for Research prompts): https://academy.claude.com/courses/claude-101/research-mode-for-deep-dives
- **Claude Academy, Claude 101,** *Your first conversation with Claude* (defining the task: write, analyze, build): https://academy.claude.com/courses/claude-101/your-first-conversation-with-claude
- **Claude Academy, AI Fluency: Framework and foundations,** *A closer look at Description* (product, process and performance description): https://academy.claude.com/courses/ai-fluency-framework-foundations/a-closer-look-at-description
- **Claude Help Center:**
  - *When should I use web search, extended thinking, and research?* (June 2, 2026: web search for one or two tool calls; Research for comprehensive gathering): https://support.claude.com/en/articles/11095361-when-should-i-use-web-search-extended-thinking-and-research
  - *Enable and use web search* (the + menu toggle; citations): https://support.claude.com/en/articles/10684626-enabling-and-using-web-search
  - *Use research on Claude* (June 2, 2026: paid plans; web search must be on): https://support.claude.com/en/articles/11088861-use-research-on-claude
  - *Change the model, effort, and thinking settings* (effort and thinking for detailed document analysis; thinking always on with Sonnet 5.5): https://support.claude.com/en/articles/8664678-change-the-model-effort-and-thinking-settings
  - *What are artifacts and how do I use them?* (something you'd put in front of someone; edit, reuse, share): https://support.claude.com/en/articles/17153992-what-are-artifacts-and-how-do-i-use-them
  - *Claude Cowork and chat are one Claude* (incognito chats open in the previous experience and can't create files): https://support.claude.com/en/articles/16761823-claude-cowork-and-chat-are-one-claude
  - *Use Claude's chat search and memory to build on previous context* (memory off for a single chat, before the first message): https://support.claude.com/en/articles/11817273-use-claude-s-chat-search-and-memory-to-build-on-previous-context
- **Pages the research job checked (2026-10-06):**
  - Claude Help Center, *Use Claude Cowork on web, desktop, and mobile* ("Updated this week": claim A, opened on camera): https://support.claude.com/en/articles/15520349-use-claude-cowork-on-web-desktop-and-mobile
  - Claude Help Center, *Get started with Claude Cowork* (the same heads-up for October 6, 2026): https://support.claude.com/en/articles/13345190-get-started-with-claude-cowork
  - Claude Platform Docs, *Model deprecations* (Haiku 4.5: "Not sooner than October 15, 2026"): https://platform.claude.com/docs/en/about-claude/model-deprecations, and *Models overview*, the page Claude cited for claim B (not opened on camera)
- **The app itself:** Claude Desktop on Linux, Chat view, Sonnet 5.5 Medium, observed 2026-10-06: the per-chat Memory switch and the Web search and Research items in the + menu, Web search carrying over to the next chat, incognito chats, the Docs document in the artifact panel and its comment, the status lines. Menus, labels and status lines can change between versions.

The "four kinds of good", the evidence-to-range dial, the strategy card ("three questions for any job"), "same six parts, different weight" and "generate first, judge later" are this course's own teaching tools, built from the sources above. They are not Anthropic lists. The hands-on material is real: this course's own published notes for Lessons 2.1 to 2.3 and its own dated claims. The shortlist criteria and every judgment are the course author's.

What you see in the lesson is a real account. Settings, Account and Memory pages were never opened, and connectors were off for the recording. A usage notice that Claude Desktop showed during recording is blurred, and the shortcut tiles on a new browser tab are masked.